

» ACE OF ACES

UNYIELDING PURSUIT OF GLORY

Honouring a great: Australian Open men's doubles champion Rohan Bopanna receives the Ace of Aces Award from Viren Rasquinha (right), and L.V. Navaneeth, CEO, The Hindu Group. RITURAJ KONWAR

A more dedicated focus on recovery and a chance discovery of a **style of yoga** have been key in Rohan Bopanna's defiant pursuit of excellence.

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Rohan Bopanna's recent exploits have breathed new life into the flailing health of Indian tennis, which has been gasping for air for some time now. The 43-year-old's journey, however, offers hope not only for the sport in the country but also for those battling the vagaries of life at large.

To become the oldest man to scale the summit of the ATP Rankings and win a Grand Slam, while playing with worn-out cartilages in both knees at a time when the sport is at its most athletic, is a testament to Bopanna's relentless perseverance.

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Bopanna's defiant pursuit of excellence, which reached its apogee when he clinched the men's doubles title at the Australia Open in January with Matthew Ebden.

"At the end of 2019, I got to know I had no cartilage left on my knees. They were fully worn out. I was on two-three painkillers a day. When I came to Bangalore, my doctor (Dr. Madan Ballal) asked me to try the PRP (Platelet-rich plasma) injections.

"He told me he can help me with the injections, but you won't be straightaway jumping as much as you want. You need to do a lot of strengthening. That's when I discovered Iyengar Yoga. I was 40 years old. I didn't think I would discover something new. At that

juncture, I was in extreme pain, so I decided to give it a try. That is something that has always carried me—my perseverance in constantly trying to find new ways to get better," Bopanna said after receiving the 'Ace of Aces' Award at the Sportstar ACES Awards 2024.

"Somewhere, the pandemic helped me. It gave me four months of time at home to focus on something and build strength in my legs again. That made a tremendous difference. Every time I went to the gym and started lifting weights, I had extreme pain in my knees. This yoga was so specific that it started building my hamstrings and quads. I could see the muscle coming back into my legs. Suddenly, after two to three